

« BEFORE

World War II saw the first American WAC detachment activated in a war zone.

GOING IN GREEN

Vietnam was only the second US war to utilize a WAC detachment. While willing to serve in Vietnam, many women were **ill prepared** for the realities of a combat zone. Basic training consisted of classes on ironing, deportment, make-up application, manners, hair styles, and speech. For the vast majority of women, weapons training was not provided.



WORLD WAR II WAC POSTER

Women's service in Vietnam was both rewarding and challenging. Like the men, women experienced the stresses of life in a combat zone—walking by body bags, seeing the wounded, and hearing the incoming choppers. However, they also battled challenges unique to their gender, including sexism, harassment, and sexual violence. Women in the military were still rare: one female warrant officer (WO) described how General Westmoreland addressed her as “mister,” because the Officers' Guide stated that this was how a WO should be addressed.

Varied roles

The first US woman to serve in Vietnam was US Army Major Anne Doering—a Combat Intelligence Officer fluent in French and Vietnamese. She was one female soldier among more than 10,000 US military personnel in Vietnam in 1962. In 1965, two US Army women, Major Kathleen Wilkes and Sergeant First Class Betty Adams, stepped off the plane to serve as advisers to the newly formed Vietnam Women's Armed Forces Corps.

General Westmoreland soon decided to bring over more women as stenographers. They arrived in 1966 and 1967, followed by many others in the ensuing years. The majority of the women who served in Vietnam were members of the Women's Army Corps (WAC). The WAC Detachment was established at Tan Son Nhut airbase and moved to Long Binh